Purr Inn: Design Report

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Purr Inn is a small shared courtyard for hotel guests. Every traveller checks in by choosing and naming a cat, and all the cats live, nap and play together in one calm, hand-drawn Japanese garden. The cat is the traveller's only identity. It is designed to soothe, to need almost no reading, and to be easy to put down, while leaving a small, warm memory of the people who were there at the same time.

Concept and premise

Purr Inn turns a hotel stay into a small shared place. Nobody steers the cats: they wander, nap, play and make friends on their own, and travellers simply look after them.

Problem, tension, solution. Travellers in a hotel pass each other in corridors but rarely connect. They arrive tired, spend quiet time alone in their rooms, and may not share a language. Purr Inn gives them one small shared place where they can be together without having to talk.

How a traveller finds it

1. The hotel advertises Purr Inn, as an app or a website.
2. The traveller gets to their room and opens it on their phone. There is no account and no form to fill in: they choose a cat, dress it, and write its name on a nameplate.
3. Their cat walks in through the inn's curtain, and the courtyard shows who else is staying right now.

The two moments it is designed for

- **Arriving after a long day.** The traveller looks around the room, then sits or lies on the bed with their phone, curious about what the hotel offers. On the way up they passed other travellers, so they feel like exploring this shared space. Even a quick look can bring an unexpected connection through the cats: "oh, these are other travellers here right now, that's nice to know." For a moment, they experience something together.
- **Winding down before sleep.** Travellers are often on their phones at the same time at night. Purr Inn gives them one calm thing to share: mostly relaxing, with a little gentle interaction, before they go to sleep.

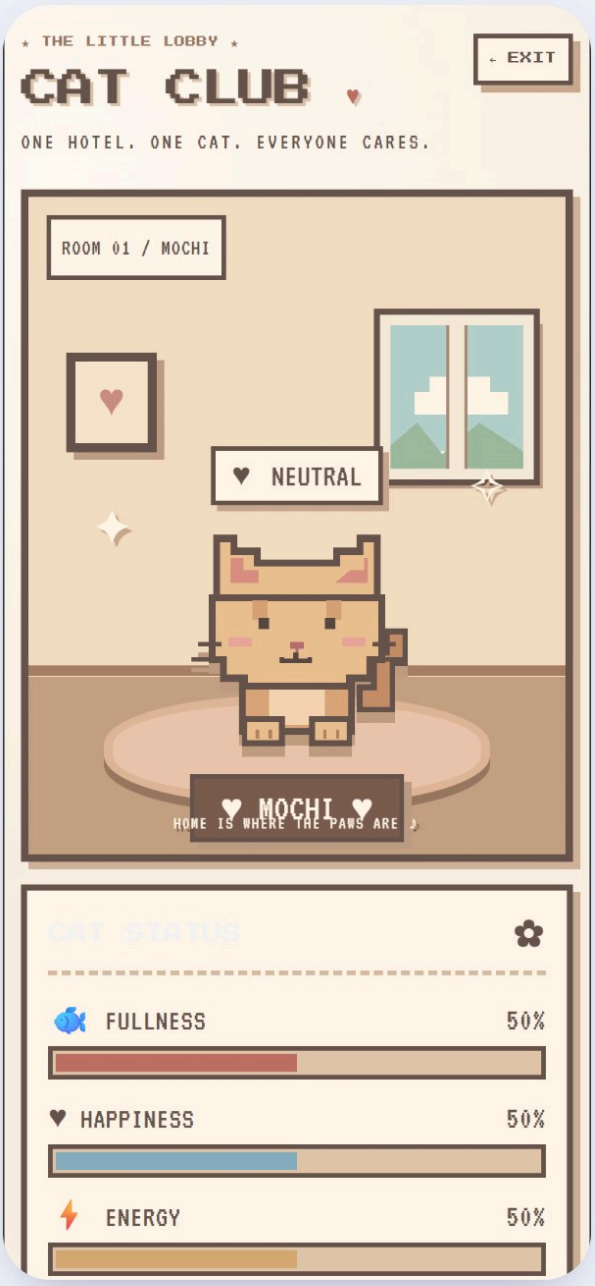
The feeling: sharing a flight. On a plane you share a space with strangers for a few hours. You might play a game on the seat screen and notice the others through a leaderboard or a simple multiplayer game, without ever talking. Purr Inn aims for that same quiet sense of being together, temporarily, in one hotel.

Easy to forget, but it leaves a mark. It is deliberately not addictive. Like agar.io, it is a small multiplayer world you can drop into in seconds and leave just as easily, then come back to at night after a day out, to unwind. When the stay ends, what remains is a small memory: a cat, a courtyard, and the people who were there at the same time.

Where it started: demo v1

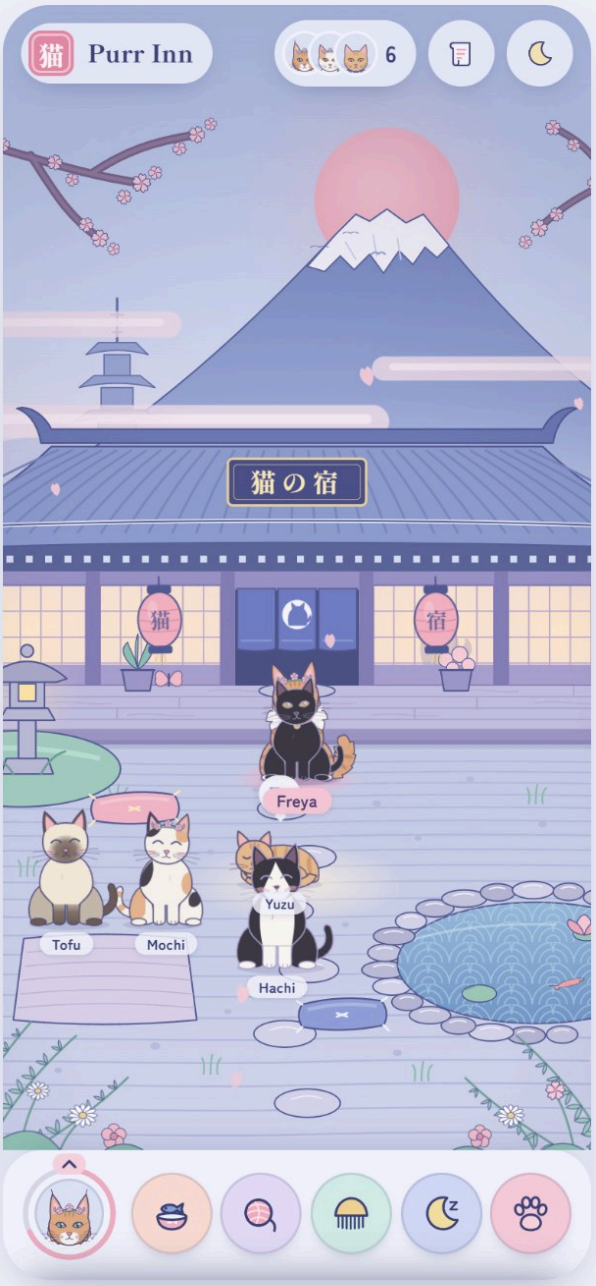
Our hackathon challenge was a hotel multiplayer game: checked-in guests look after a virtual cat and can see who else is online, who has joined and who is in the hotel. Our team's first version (demo v1) proved the idea worked, but it was built from placeholders: a temporary pixel cat, fake guests named Alex and Jamie, and template text.

The evening before the final day, I set out to change the entire design. I wanted it visually compelling: a botanical style combined with ukiyo-e-inspired cats, smooth and seamless animation, and an interface that matches the art. It had to be mobile first. Each traveller should choose and customise their own cat on arrival (a Norwegian Forest Cat for the demo), see other people's cats, and watch the cats interact on their own, without anyone steering them.



Demo v1

one room, one placeholder cat, text panels



Purr Inn

one shared courtyard, everyone's cats

	Demo v1 (placeholders)	Purr Inn now
Name	Pet Room / Cat Club	Purr Inn, with 猫の宿 ("the cats' inn") on the plaque
The cats	One shared cat, Mochi, for the whole hotel	Every traveller chooses, customises and names their own cat, which becomes their only identity

	Demo v1 (placeholders)	Purr Inn now
Cat artwork	A temporary pixel-art stand-in	Hand-drawn ukiyo-e-style cats: seven breeds, three poses, soft fur strokes
The space	One room, "ROOM 01"	One shared Japanese courtyard under Mount Fuji, with no room numbers
Style	Retro pixel, beige and brown, hard outlines and pixel fonts	Ukiyo-e meets botanical, soft pastel blue, soft lines with fine detail
Words	English capitals everywhere, stats as percentages	Almost wordless: pictures and icons; the only words are cats' names
Caring	Four labelled emoji buttons in a side panel	Five coloured icon buttons under the thumb
Feedback	Bars and numbers change	The cat reacts in the courtyard: a hand strokes it, a bowl appears, hearts float up
Other guests	A text list with letter avatars	Other travellers appear only as their cats: in the courtyard, as faces at the top, in a wordless diary
Movement	The cat bobs in place	Cats wander, nap, play and make friends on their own
Time of day	Fixed	The same courtyard by day and by night
Device	Desktop first; a long scrolling page on phones	Phone first, one-handed, no scrolling in the courtyard

How it got here: three rounds of direction

The design moved in four rounds. In each, I wrote the direction as the designer, an AI coding assistant built it, and I reviewed the result before asking for the next round.

Round 1: make it beautiful and alive (Neko no Yado)

What I asked for:

- Change the entire design: a botanical style combined with ukiyo-e-inspired cats, based on my "cat pictures ideas" reference folder.
- Make it visually compelling, with smooth and seamless animation.
- An interface that meshes with the art style.
- Mobile first.
- Choose or customise your cat when you arrive, with a Norwegian Forest Cat for the demo.
- See other people's cats, and people caring for their cats.
- Cats interact with each other on their own, without anyone controlling them.

What changed: the single pixel room became a shared ukiyo-e courtyard with an inn, a koi pond, cherry blossoms and Mount Fuji. Hand-drawn cats now blink, flick their ears and swish their tails, and they walk, groom, nap and meet friends by themselves. The app was called Neko no Yado, "the cats' inn".

Round 2: quieter, wordless, made for travellers (Purr Stay)

What I asked for:

- Remove room numbers: they don't feel realistic for a hotel app.
- Fit the quiet moments of a traveller's day: checking in, arriving in the room with nothing to do yet, or winding down before bed.
- Less text, so travellers with different languages can share it without thinking about language. Symbols should be obvious or easy to figure out. Breed names and Japanese symbols can stay.
- Choose the cat without words too: show the patterns themselves, not their names.
- Keep everything in the middle, so the eye isn't pulled to one side first.
- A night mode: darker but not too dark, in a soft dark-brown pastel that matches the wood.
- A slightly darker courtyard: keep the light wooden floor, but tone down its brightness.
- A little more artistic detail, but no texture that distracts.
- A softer finish: lines less sharp and less bold.
- Smoother animation, with nothing that draws the eye to itself, like rotating shapes.
- Gentler colours: the orange was too strong.
- A subtle touch of soft pastel pink.
- Make it obvious that the stats can be tapped, make your own cat easy to spot, and show clearly what happens when you pet it.
- Keep the courtyard diary, with less text and no timestamps: just a heart between two cats, like Mochi and Yuzu.

- Name the hotel Purr Stay.
- The feeling of sharing a flight, and a full set of design principles (see Design principles).

What changed: text disappeared almost everywhere. The cat picker became picture swatches in one centred column. Your cat got a soft pink glow and pink name tag, and every action now shows in the courtyard: a hand, a comb, a bowl or a yarn ball. A ring around your cat's face fills as it is cared for and opens into four picture gauges.

Round 3: soft blue, measured and polished (Purr Inn)

What I asked for:

- It was too brown: switch to blue, taking colours from my "colours" reference folder without going beyond them or getting too bright.
- Bring in the soft pastel feel of those pictures, while keeping the pronounced details.
- The controls with white borders were hard to see: make them clearer, and remove the Japanese characters under them.
- Occasional shooting stars at night, and by day birds far away, drawn as just two curved lines.
- Make the background more symmetrical, measured like a painting: you can't sense the symmetry, but it is pleasing, like looking at art.
- Rename Purr Stay to Purr Inn.
- Polish everything, and keep the code and logic simple.

What changed: a soft pastel-blue palette by day and deep periwinkle by night, with pink and warm lantern light as accents. Each care button got its own soft colour, and the characters under them are gone. Birds and shooting stars now cross the sky, and the whole scene was re-laid out on a measured grid (see Visual language).

Round 4: one identity, the cat

What I asked for:

- Drop the step where travellers type their own name. They only choose and name their cat, and the cat is their identity everywhere.
- Make it obvious that they are naming the cat, through the placement and design of the field rather than an explanation.
- Cut anything at check-in that adds interface without adding to the shared experience.
- Keep an anonymous id behind each cat, so two cats can share a name.
- Simplify and comment the code without changing the demo, so our team can review it.

What changed: check-in is now a single screen. You choose a cat, dress it, and write its name on a pink nameplate hung right under it, the same pink tag that follows it around the courtyard. Everywhere else, travellers appear only as their cats: in the courtyard, on the pill you see when you tap a cat, in the faces sheet and in the diary.

Design principles

Every screen follows the same rules, written in round 2 and kept since. Purr Inn is not a game demanding the traveller's attention: it is a small shared place that happens to exist alongside their stay.

Principle	How it shows up in Purr Inn
The cats and the courtyard come first; the interface is secondary and quiet	The courtyard fills the screen. Controls sit small at the top and bottom edges, with no large panels, cards or text blocks
Every important action is answered in the courtyard itself	Petting shows a hand stroking the cat, hearts and a purr; feeding puts down a bowl; brushing shows a comb; playing tosses a yarn ball. Numbers are never the main feedback
Other travellers are noticeable, never noisy	Their cats wander, sleep, play and sit together. Only your own cat shows every sound word
One identity: the cat	Travellers are known only by their cat's face and name, everywhere in the app. Nobody types or shows anything about themselves
No chat, player lists, competitive leaderboards or lobby	Presence is shown through faces and cats. The diary records small shared moments, not scores
Comfortable when doing nothing	The cats keep living on their own while petals fall, mist drifts, koi circle and lanterns sway
Never nag	No notifications, badges, streaks, progress systems or prompts to come back. While you are away, your cat just gets a little hungry or sleepy

Principle	How it shows up in Purr Inn
Prefer removing to adding	Room numbers, the sign-up form, labels, timestamps, captions under buttons and long text were all removed
Made for one hand on a phone	Care buttons sit where the thumb rests; every tap target is 44 px or larger; no hover, precise taps or scrolling in the courtyard
Icon-first and language-light, without hurting usability	The only words are cats' names, breed names and a few Japanese symbols. Everything else is an icon or a picture
Intuitive, soft and spaced out	Rounded shapes, soft shadows, generous spacing, and one centred column when choosing a cat

Visual language

Purr Inn looks like a soft woodblock print come to life. It blends ukiyo-e, the Japanese woodblock print, with botanical illustration: flat areas of colour, soft indigo outlines, and plants drawn with care.

The style

- **Ukiyo-e details:** Mount Fuji, a pagoda, stylised bands of mist, a wave pattern in the koi pond, paper lanterns, a curtain over the door with a cat crest, paper screens and a wooden deck.
- **Botanical details:** cherry-blossom branches, ferns, daisies, peach blossom, wisteria and potted plants frame the scene.
- **Soft lines, pronounced details:** outlines are lighter and softer than a real woodblock print, but the details stay crisp. Texture is held back to a faint paper grain, so travellers look at the cats rather than the surfaces.
- **Cats in the same style:** seven breeds in three poses (sitting, walking, sleeping), with brush-stroke tabby markings, soft long fur on the Norwegian Forest Cat, and a blush when they are happy.
- **Gentle motion only:** everything eases in and out, nothing spins or flashes, and each cat blinks, flicks an ear or swishes its tail at its own pace.

A measured picture

I wanted the background to feel like a painting where every object was placed with care: you don't notice the symmetry, you just find it pleasing to look at. The scene follows a hidden grid:

- A centre line runs through the door, its curtain, the 猫の宿 plaque and the stepping-stone path.
- Pairs mirror each other at equal distances from that line: the two paper lanterns, the potted plants, the wisteria, the paper screens and the posts.
- The sun by day, and the moon by night, rests on Fuji's peak close to the golden section of the width, balanced by the pagoda on the left.
- Cherry branches frame both top corners, and the mist bands alternate sides in a steady rhythm.
- The stepping stones grow toward the viewer at an even rate, and the rake lines in the gravel widen like a perspective grid.
- The garden itself is balanced, not mirrored: a stone lantern and moss on the left, the koi pond on the right. That is why the order is felt rather than seen.



The hidden grid

Centre line through the plaque, the door and the stepping stones

Mirrored pairs: wisteria, lanterns and potted plants

The sun rests on Fuji's peak, near the golden section of the width

Felt, not seen

Stepping stones grow toward you at an even rate

Rake lines widen like a perspective grid

The garden is balanced, not mirrored: a stone lantern on the left, the koi pond on the right

Colour and atmosphere

Soft blue is the default because it soothes: after a long journey, the first thing a traveller sees should calm them. The palette comes from my "colours" reference folder of pastel paintings: periwinkle streets, Fuji under a pink sun, lavender trees and a blue night city framed by cherry blossom. I kept it no brighter than those pictures. Every colour has a job for the traveller:

Colour	Where it appears	Why it matters to a traveller
Soft periwinkle blue (the default)	Sky, roof, Mount Fuji, the interface	Calming after a long day of travel; the colour of sky and water, easy on tired eyes

Colour	Where it appears	Why it matters to a traveller
Pastel pink	Your cat's glow, name tag and nameplate, cherry blossom, the sun, the lanterns, the main button	Warmth and affection. It marks "you" and what you do. Cherry blossom also stands for a beautiful moment that passes, like a stay
Warm lantern light (cream and soft gold)	Paper screens, lanterns, the moon, fireflies, the plaque	Hospitality: a lit room waiting for you, a little warmth inside the cool blue
Lavender	The wooden deck, the gravel, wisteria	Bridges the blue and the pink, so nothing in the scene feels harsh
Mint and soft teal	Moss, ferns and leaves	A breath of garden for someone who has been indoors or on the road all day
Deep periwinkle, never black	The whole scene and interface at night	Low light for the hour before sleep: no pure black, no harsh white text, softer contrast
Five soft button colours: peach, lavender, mint, periwinkle, pink	The five care buttons	Each action is recognised by its colour and icon, without reading

Contrast stays gentle everywhere, while the outlines keep details clear. The result is soothing without looking washed out.

Day and night

Purr Inn has a light mode for the day and a soft dark mode for the night, and both show the same physical courtyard at a different time, not just a darker theme. It follows the local time by itself (night runs from 7 pm to 6 am), and one tap on the sun or moon at the top switches it.



Day

pink sun, birds, butterflies



Night

moon, lantern light, fireflies

	Day	Night
Sky	A pink sun resting on Fuji's peak. Far-off birds, drawn as two curved lines, drift across	A pale moon in the same place, and stars. Now and then a white or pink shooting star streaks behind the blossom

	Day	Night
Light	Soft pastel daylight	Lanterns glow, the paper screens are lit from inside, and a lamp shines in the pagoda
Garden life	Cherry petals drift down, and cats chase a butterfly	Fewer petals, fireflies drift, and cats chase a firefly
Interface	Light periwinkle and lavender-white	Deep periwinkle with soft light text

The night version is made for the moment that matters most: winding down in bed. It is dim, warm and quiet, and never harsh on the eyes in a dark room.

The experience, screen by screen

A traveller goes from opening the link to having a cat in the courtyard in a few taps, and the only word they type is their cat's name.



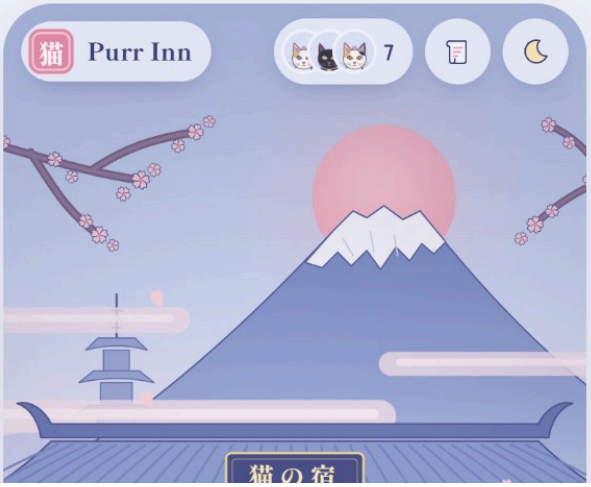
1. Choose and name your cat

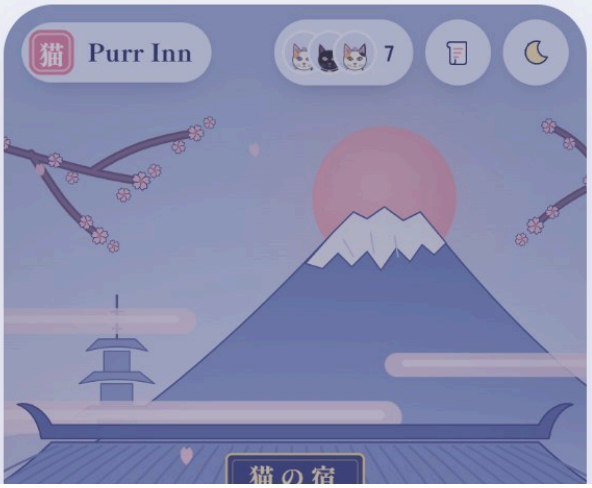
the pink nameplate hangs under it

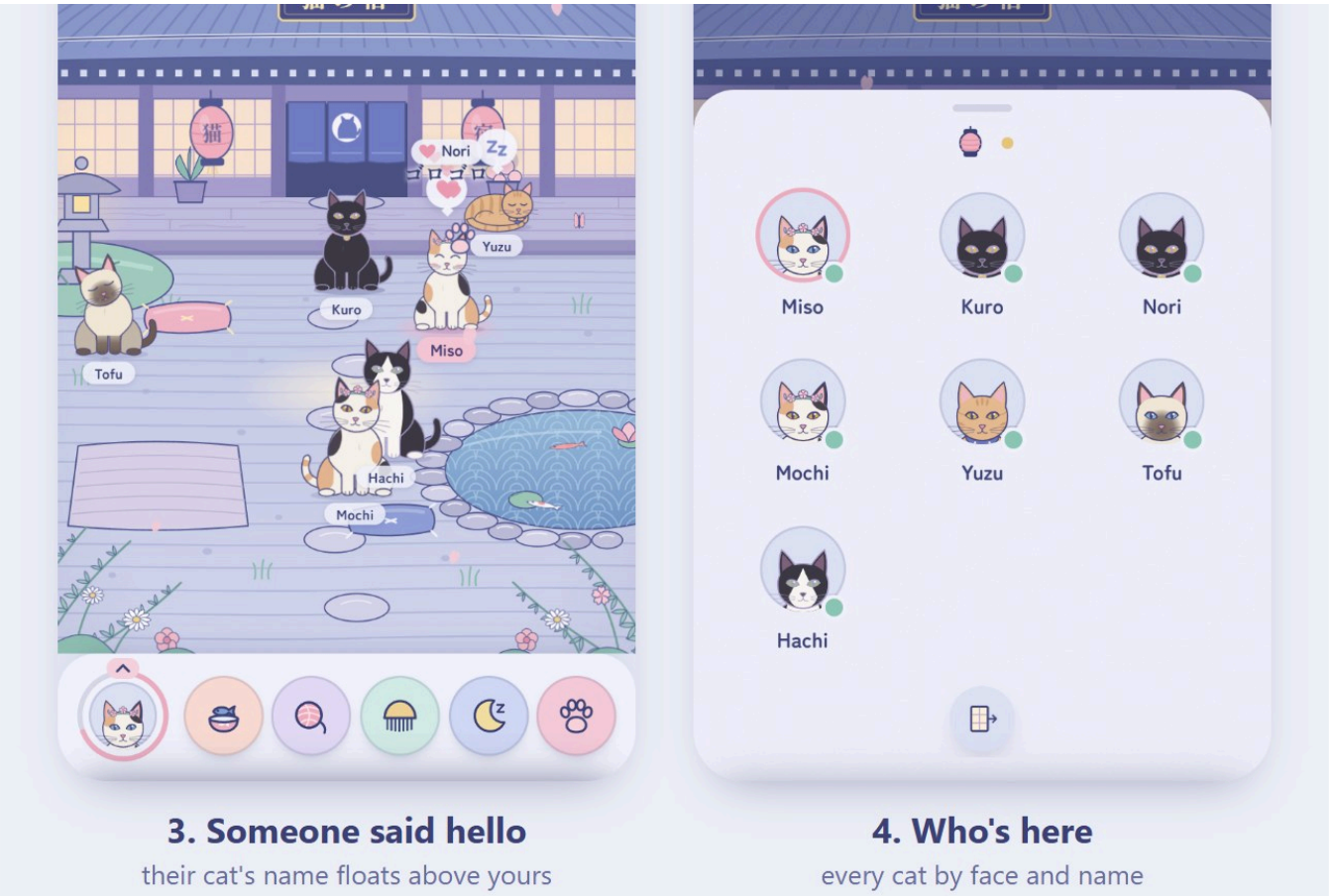


2. Say hello to another cat

its face, its name: pet or treat







3. Someone said hello
their cat's name floats above yours

4. Who's here
every cat by face and name

1. **Check-in: choose and name a cat.** The first screen is the cat itself, sitting on a cushion in front of a pink sun, or a pale moon at night; tapping it makes it purr. Right under it hangs a pink nameplate with a small pencil: the cat's name goes there, and a dice suggests one. Below, in one centred column, every choice is a picture: breed faces, coat colours, patterns, white markings, fur length, eye colours, and a sakura crown, bell or indigo scarf. Small faces at the top show who is already staying.
2. **Arrival.** Paper doors slide open on "ようこそ" ("welcome"), and the new cat walks into the courtyard through the inn's curtain. Everyone else sees the curtain sway and the cat's name appear at the door.
3. **The courtyard.** Everyone's cats live here. Yours has a soft pink glow beneath it and the same pink name tag, so it is easy to find; other tags fade when cats crowd together.
4. **Caring.** Five buttons sit under the thumb: feed, play, brush, nap and pet. The tapped icon floats from the button to the cat, and the cat reacts: it eats from a bowl, chases a yarn ball, is combed until fluffy, curls up to sleep, or is stroked by a hand while hearts float up. Tapping the garden tosses a yarn ball there. If the cat is too tired to play, the nap button gives a gentle nudge.
5. **How your cat is doing.** A ring around your cat's face at the bottom left fills as it is cared for. Tapping it opens four picture gauges (food, happiness, energy, fluff) and a mood icon; a gauge pulses softly when it runs low.

6. **Saying hello to another cat.** Tapping any cat opens a small pill with its face and name, and two buttons: pet, or give a treat. Its traveller sees your cat's name float above theirs, with a heart or a fish.
7. **Who's here.** The faces at the top open a sheet of every cat staying, by face and name. Yours is ringed in pink, and a door icon checks you out; everyone else then sees your cat walk out through the door.
8. **The diary.** A scroll icon opens tiny shared moments told with cat faces and icons, such as Mochi, a heart, Yuzu, or Nori, a paw, Miso when one traveller's cat greets another. There are no timestamps.
9. **Sound words.** Japanese sound words float up like a comic: ゴロゴロ for a purr, パクパク for munching, ふわふわ for fluffy fur, スヤスヤ for sleep. They read as pictures of sound, so no translation is needed. Only your own cat shows them all; other cats only purr when loved and say hello when they arrive, which keeps the courtyard calm.

Together, without pressure

Other travellers are present through their cats, not through chat or profiles. The courtyard gives a subtle sense that real people are here at the same time, without asking anyone to talk or compete.

- **Your cat is you.** Nobody types their own name or shares anything about themselves. Travellers recognise each other by their cats, which keeps the courtyard about the cats and makes joining feel easy and safe.
- **The cats carry the social life.** They boop noses, groom each other, chase, play and nap side by side. Travellers meet through their cats, with no shared language needed.
- **Small, kind gestures.** Anyone can pet another cat or give it a treat. Its traveller sees whose cat said hello, as that cat's name floats above theirs, and their cat really does get happier.
- **Arrivals feel like a hotel.** A new cat walks in through the door, the curtain sways, and its name appears at the entrance for a moment.
- **Everyone sees the same moment.** The same cat sits in the same spot on every phone, so two travellers looking at the courtyard really are looking at the same scene.
- **Never empty.** A few simulated resident cats, and one that keeps checking in and out, keep the courtyard gently alive even when you are the only real guest.
- **A diary instead of a leaderboard.** Like noticing others through a leaderboard on a flight, but without the competition: the diary keeps small shared moments instead of scores.

What comes next: sound

Sound is the next layer, and it will follow the same calm rules as the visuals.

- **Music:** a soothing Japanese soundtrack for the courtyard, slow and quiet.
- **Cat sounds:** soft meows and purrs when you care for your cat and when cats greet each other.
- **How it should behave:** gentle and easy to turn off, and quieter at night, since travellers may be in bed or sharing a room.